HMS Your Town

British towns and the Royal Navy ships named after them, from Wikidata

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Abstract

Many British towns have given their name to a warship. I ask which towns, how often, when, and what became of the ships, using the 6,006 Royal Navy ships named "HMS" in Wikidata. Because Wikidata records what a ship was named after for only 261 of them, I match ship names strictly to British towns and cities, excluding classes and names that honour other things, and flag names that are also noble titles. The result is 394 ships named after 135 towns and cities. Gloucester and Newcastle upon Tyne have had nine ships each; 28 towns have had five or more and 50 just one. 63% of the towns lie within 10 km of the open sea. Town names were common in the later 1600s (33% of ships commissioned 1650 to 1699), rare through the 1800s (under 3%) and common again after 1950 (23%). The question of fate can hardly be answered from open data: only 24% of the ships have any recorded end, 11 of them a loss. Ships named after places in other navies' Wikidata records show the same habit, most of all in the United States Navy (146 ships named after American towns and cities).

Keywords: naval history; ship names; Royal Navy; toponymy; Wikidata; civic identity; open data

1 Introduction

A warship named after a town is a link between the town and the Navy: the ship carries the town's name, crest and often gifts from its people, and the town follows the ship. This short study asks which British towns have been honoured in this way, how many times, in which eras, and what happened to the ships. It accompanies an interactive map (https://maps.tristanhotham.com/ships-named/).

2 Data

Ships. The ships are the items in Wikidata (Wikidata, 2026) operated by the Royal Navy whose label begins "HMS" (6,006 ships), with their class, commissioning and decommissioning dates where present, their significant events (launch, commissioning, sinking, shipwreck, breaking up and so on) and, for 261 ships, the item they are named after (property P138). A second extract lists ships of all navies with P138 pointing to a place with coordinates, used for the international comparison.

Towns. British towns and cities come from Wikidata's settlements in the United Kingdom, with coordinates, population and type. For matching I keep places typed as town, market town, city, county town, seaside resort or new town, or with 10,000 people or more, inside the bounds of the United Kingdom.

3 Methods

3.1 Matching ships to towns

A ship is linked to a town in one of three ways. Where its P138 is a British town or city, that town is used (10 ships). Otherwise its name after "HMS" must equal a town's name exactly (350 ships), or be "*town* Castle", for ships named after a town's castle (34 ships, most of them Castle-class corvettes of 1944). Where several towns share a name, the most populous is used and the match flagged; common short forms are mapped to the town the Navy meant (Newcastle to Newcastle upon Tyne, Yarmouth to Great Yarmouth, Berwick to Berwick-upon-Tweed, Londonderry to Derry, Shoreham to Shoreham-by-Sea, Milford to Milford Haven, Weston to Weston-super-Mare), and three castles are placed where they stand (Leeds Castle, in Kent, is excluded; Caistor Castle is Caister Castle in Norfolk; Hadleigh Castle is in Essex). Excluded are ships whose P138 is anything but a British town (a person, a foreign place, a county or a river), classes named after other things (the Hunt-class destroyers after fox hunts, the Racecourse-class after racecourses, the River, Flower, Bird, Tree, Isles and Dance classes, and the classes named after counties: the Monmouth and Devonshire armoured cruisers, the County-class heavy cruisers and the County-class destroyers), and a list of names that honour people, battles, rivers, counties or foreign places though a British town shares them (Nelson, Wellington, Marlborough, Dunkirk, Gibraltar, Halifax, Colne and others; the list is in the code). In all 675 ships were excluded by these rules. Names that are also titles of royal dukes or peers (York, Gloucester, Lancaster, Newcastle and others) are kept but flagged: 167 ships carry such a name, and some of the older ones may honour the duke or earl rather than the town.

3.2 Years and fates

A ship's year is its commissioning year (266 matched ships); otherwise the median commissioning year of its class when three or more members are dated, or the year in the name of an "Establishment" class (54 ships). 320 of the 394 ships have a year. Fates come from the ship's events, in this order of precedence: sunk, wrecked, scuttled or destroyed; captured; broken up or scrapped; sold or transferred; decommissioned; and, for ships commissioned since 1985 with no end recorded, "in service or recent".

4 Results

4.1 Which towns

Figure 1 maps the 135 towns. 112 are in England, 12 in Scotland, 8 in Wales and 3 in Northern Ireland. The most-named (Figure 2) are Gloucester and Newcastle upon Tyne with nine ships each, Glasgow with eight, and Chatham, Falmouth, London, Maidstone, Pembroke, Scarborough and York with seven. They are old ports, cathedral cities and the dockyard towns of the Navy. 85 of the towns (63%) lie within 10 km of the open sea, measured to the Natural Earth coastline (Natural Earth, 2026).

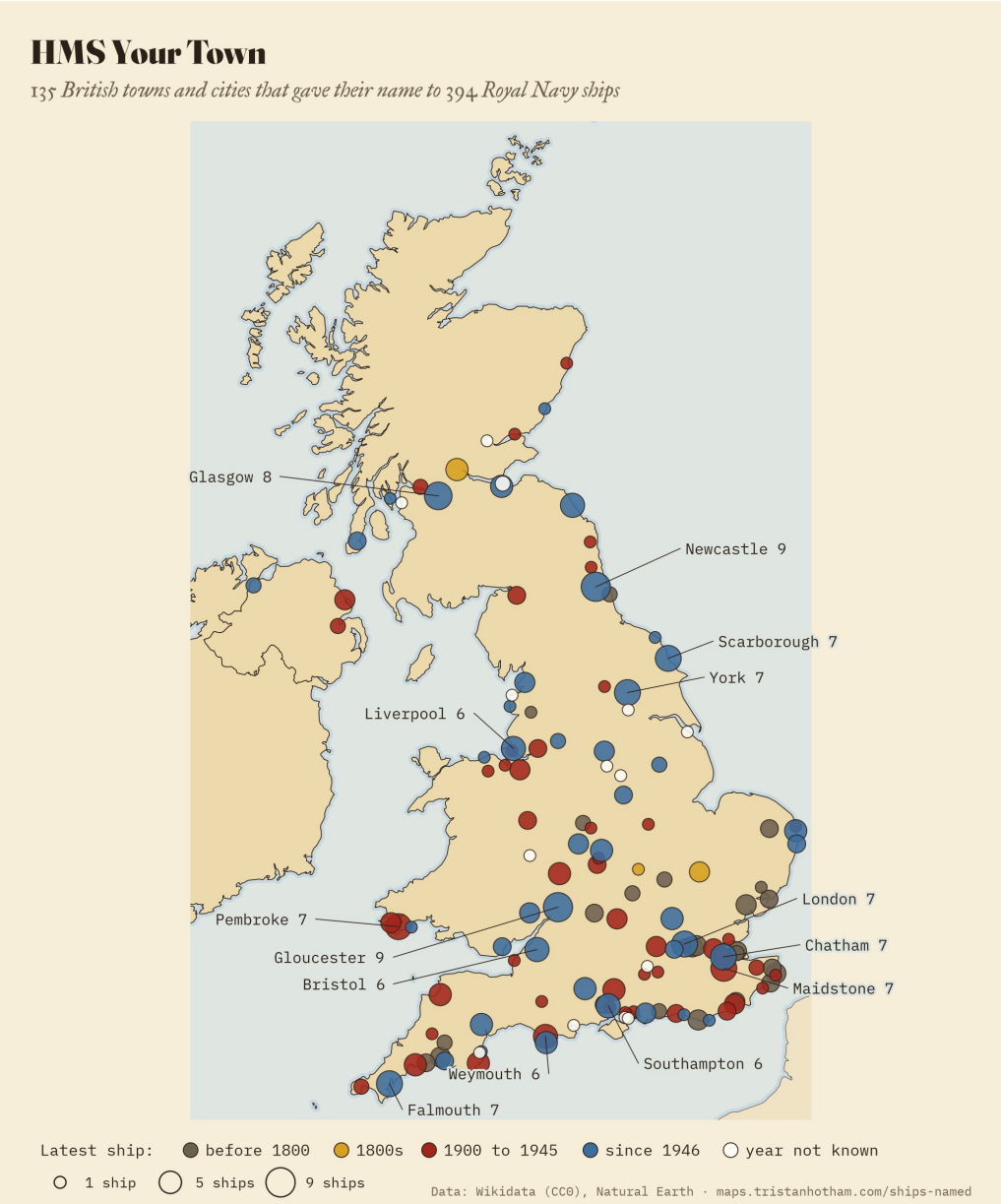


Figure 1: British towns and cities with a Royal Navy ship of their name, sized by the number of ships and coloured by the era of the latest.

4.2 When

Town names follow a long cycle (Figure 3). Of the Royal Navy ships in Wikidata commissioned from 1650 to 1699, 33.3% (65 of 195) bear a British town's name, and 30.1% from 1700 to 1749. The share then falls to 6.4%, 2.3% and 1.3% in the following half centuries, and rises again to 4.3% in 1900 to 1949 and 22.8% in 1950 to 1999, the years of the Castle-class corvettes (21 ships), the town-named frigates and the Type 42 destroyers named after cities (14). The early peak is partly a peak of noble titles that were also town names.

4.3 Two towns by hand

Lancaster has 4 ships: HMS Lancaster (1694), HMS Lancaster (1797), the corvette HMS Lancaster Castle (1944) and the Type 23 frigate HMS Lancaster (1992), which like the rest of its class is

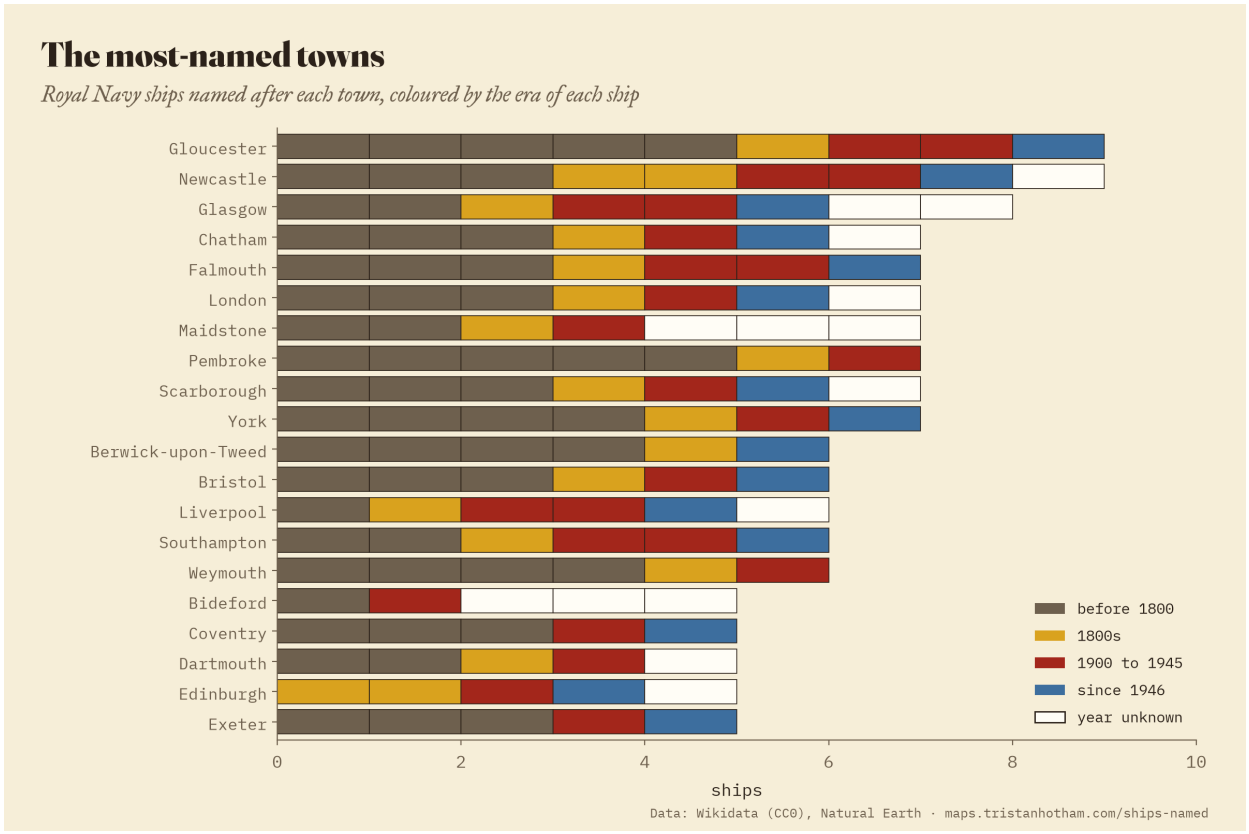


Figure 2: The twenty towns with most ships; each block is one ship, coloured by era.

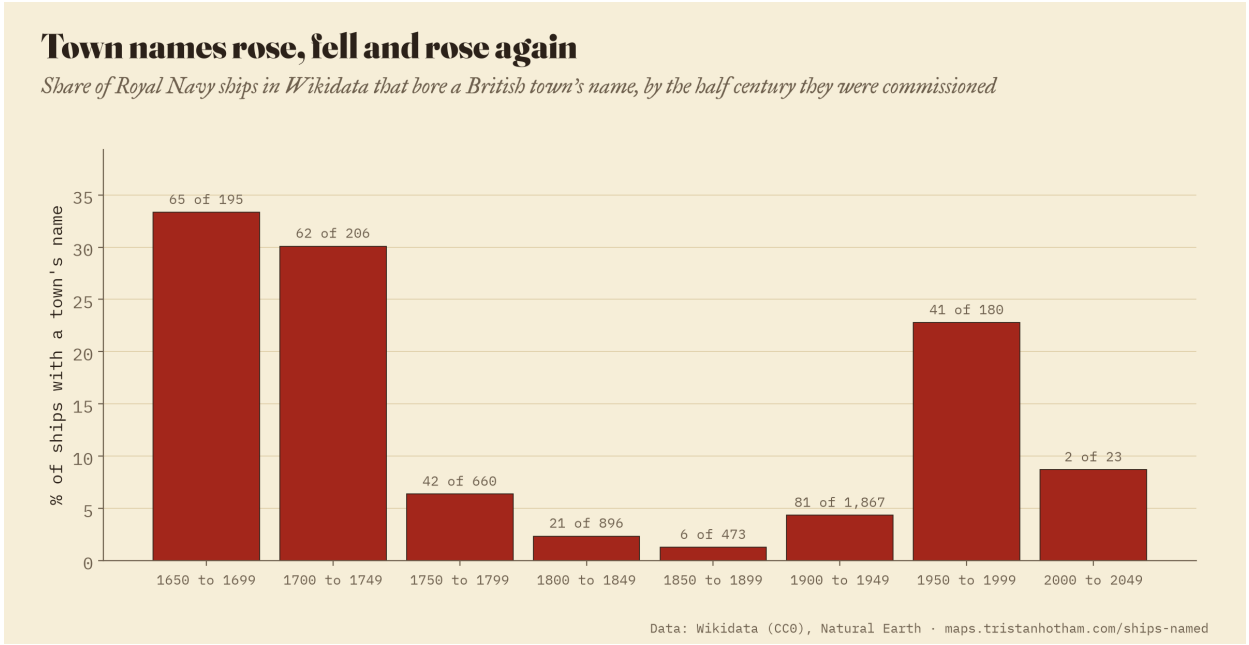


Figure 3: Share of Royal Navy ships with a British town's name by half century of commissioning (or the class's typical year).



Figure 4: Recorded fates of the town-named ships.

named after a dukedom. The Monmouth-class armoured cruiser of 1902 is excluded as one of a class named after counties, and the Town-class destroyer of 1940 is in Wikidata only under its American name. Barrow-in-Furness, a great shipbuilding town, has none in the data.

4.4 Fates

Only 94 of the 394 ships (23.9%) have any recorded end (Figure 4): 76 only a decommissioning, 11 a loss, 2 a breaking up, and 5 are recent ships with no end recorded. The recorded losses include HMS Gloucester (sunk off Crete in 1941) and HMS Sheffield and HMS Coventry (lost in the Falklands in 1982). Wikidata simply does not hold the fate of most Royal Navy ships, and a map of fates is mostly a map of gaps.

4.5 Other navies

Among ships of all navies whose Wikidata entry names the place they honour, the United States Navy has 470, 146 of them named after American towns and cities (Figure 5). The Royal Australian Navy also names ships mainly after its towns, while the Imperial Japanese Navy's place-named ships honour mountains, rivers and provinces, almost never towns. These counts reflect how often Wikidata records P138, which varies by navy, more than the navies' habits.

5 Limitations

Wikidata's list of Royal Navy ships is long but incomplete and uneven across periods. Only 261 of the 6,006 ships (4.3%) record what they were named after, and the matched ships are 6.6% of all of them. Whole groups can be missing: 43 of the 45 Town-class destroyers transferred from the United States in 1940, each named after a town common to both countries, are in Wikidata only under their American names. 167 matched ships (42.4%) carry a name that is also a noble title; without them 227 ships and 93 towns remain. Matching by name is inference: a ship may honour a duke whose title is a town, or a different place of the same name, and some names in the excluded

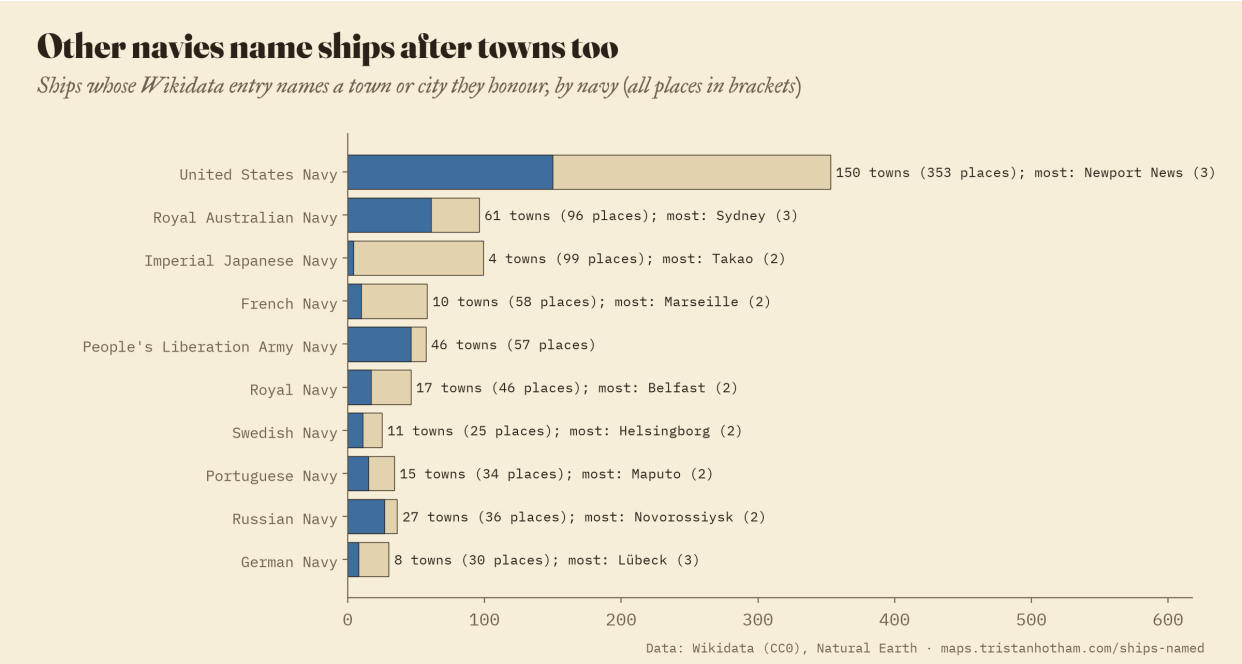


Figure 5: Ships named after towns and cities (blue) among ships named after any place, by navy, from Wikidata's "named after".

list could honour a town after all. Years are missing for some ships and approximate for others. Fates are recorded for a quarter of the ships, so nothing here measures how many town-named ships were lost. A printed register such as Colledge and Warlow (2006) would fill many of these gaps.

6 Conclusion

A warship of the town's name is an old and widespread honour: 135 British towns in the data have had one, mostly ports and old cities, and the fashion has come and gone over three and a half centuries. What became of the ships is the part the open record cannot yet tell.

Data and code availability

Derived data (each matched ship with its town, year and recorded fate; each town; the international table), the exclusion rules and all code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/ships-named and in the Zenodo record https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.24052719. Code MIT; text, figures and derived data CC BY 4.0. Source data from Wikidata (CC0).

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

References

Colledge, J. J. and Warlow, B. (2006) *Ships of the Royal Navy: The Complete Record of all Fighting Ships of the Royal Navy*. Revised edition. London: Chatham Publishing.

Natural Earth (2026) Admin 0 countries, 1:10m. Public domain. https://www.naturalearthdata.com/

Wikidata (2026) Wikidata, the free knowledge base. CC0. https://www.wikidata.org/

A Every town

Table 1: Every British town or city with a Royal Navy ship of its name in the data, by number of ships. Title: the name is also a noble title.

Town	Nation	Ships	First	Latest	Title
Gloucester	England	9	1654	1985	yes
Newcastle upon Tyne	England	9	1653	1978	yes
Glasgow	Scotland	8	1741	1979	
Chatham	England	7	1691	1990	
Falmouth	England	7	1693	1961	
London	England	7	1656	1987	
Maidstone	England	7	1744	1937	
Pembroke	Wales	7	1689	1944	yes
Scarborough	England	7	1708	1957	
York	England	7	1654	1985	yes
Berwick-upon-Tweed	England	6	1689	1961	
Bristol	England	6	1653	1973	yes
Liverpool	England	6	1758	1982	
Southampton	England	6	1693	1981	yes
Weymouth	England	6	1693	1911	
Bideford	England	5	1733	1932	
Coventry	England	5	1658	1978	yes
Dartmouth	England	5	1693	1911	yes
Edinburgh	Scotland	5	1811	1985	yes
Exeter	England	5	1680	1980	yes
Fowey	England	5	1744	1931	
Great Yarmouth	England	5	1653	1960	
Portland	England	5	1653	2001	yes
Salisbury	England	5	1698	1958	yes
St Albans	England	5	1687	2002	yes
Stirling	Scotland	5	1679	1811	
Winchester	England	5	1693	1918	yes
Worcester	England	5	1698	1922	yes
Birmingham	England	4	1914	1976	
Cambridge	England	4	1666	1815	yes
Chester	England	4	1691	1916	yes
Chichester	England	4	1695	1958	yes
Colchester	England	4	1694	1746	
Deal	England	4	1708	1756	
Greenwich	England	4	1666	1747	
Lancaster	England	4	1694	1992	yes
Larne	Northern Ireland	4	1813	1943	
Milford Haven	Wales	4	1759	1932	
Monmouth	Wales	4	1667	1993	yes

Town	Nation	Ships	First	Latest	Title
Oxford	England	4	1674	1944	yes
Saltash	England	4	1745	1745	
Seaford	England	4	1733	1733	
Sheffield	England	4	1937	1988	
Tilbury	England	4	1699	1918	
Winchelsea	England	4	1733	1918	yes
Windsor	England	4	1695	1918	yes
Woolwich	England	4	1675	1749	
Burford	England	3	1679	1757	yes
Campbeltown	Scotland	3	1940	1989	
Cardiff	Wales	3	1916	1979	
Carlisle	England	3	1693	1918	yes
Dover	England	3	1654	1654	
Harwich	England	3	1674	1743	
Hastings	England	3	1694	1930	
Looe	England	3	1694	1741	
Lowestoft	England	3	1914	1961	
Norwich	England	3	1691	1745	
Nottingham	England	3	1703	1983	yes
Orford	England	3	1698	1916	yes
Plymouth	England	3	1653	1961	yes
Redbridge	England	3	1798	1798	
Richmond	England	3	1757	1995	yes
Rochester	England	3	1693	1932	yes
Rye	England	3	1708	1733	
Sandwich	England	3	1679	1759	yes
Sheerness	England	3	1741	1741	
Shoreham-by-Sea	England	3	1708	1932	
Shrewsbury	England	3	1695	1944	yes
Warwick	England	3	1696	1918	yes
Arundel	England	2	1751	1751	yes
Bedford	England	2	1698	1775	yes
Belfast	Northern Ireland	2	1939	1939	
Buckingham	England	2	1731	1751	yes
Canterbury	England	2	1693	1915	
Derry	Northern Ireland	2	1961	1961	
Dumbarton	Scotland	2	1944	1944	
Leith	Scotland	2			
Lichfield	England	2	1695	1746	
Lincoln	England	2	1695	1960	yes
Manchester	England	2	1938	1982	
Penzance	England	2	1931	1931	
Portsmouth	England	2	1650	1650	yes
Queenborough	England	2	1751	1751	
Sunderland	England	2	1694	1724	yes
Tavistock	England	2	1745	1747	yes
Aberdeen	Scotland	1	1936	1936	
Alnwick	England	1	1944	1944	
Birkenhead	England	1	1915	1915	
Blackpool	England	1	1958	1958	
Brighton	England	1	1961	1961	
Caister-on-Sea	England	1	1944	1944	
Chesterfield	England	1			yes
Denbigh	Wales	1	1944	1944	
Dundee	Scotland	1	1933	1933	
Eastbourne	England	1	1958	1958	
Farnborough	England	1			
Farnham	England	1	1945	1945	
Fleetwood	England	1			
Flint	Wales	1	1944	1944	

Town	Nation	Ships	First	Latest	Title
Folkestone	England	1	1930	1930	
Gosport	England	1			
Grimsby	England	1			
Guildford	England	1	1944	1944	
Hadleigh	England	1	1943	1943	
Havant	England	1	1939	1939	
Ipswich	England	1	1694	1694	
Kenilworth	England	1	1943	1943	
Kennington	England	1	1733	1733	
Knaresborough	England	1	1944	1944	
Largs	Scotland	1			
Launceston	England	1	1944	1944	
Ludlow	England	1			yes
Mansfield	England	1			
Montrose	Scotland	1	1994	1994	yes
Morpeth	England	1	1944	1944	
Northampton	England	1	1876	1876	yes
Oakham	England	1	1944	1944	
Perth	Scotland	1			yes
Poole	England	1			
Portchester	England	1	1944	1944	
Preston	England	1	1757	1757	
Rhyl	Wales	1	1960	1960	
Rothesay	Scotland	1	1960	1960	
Selby	England	1			
Sherborne	England	1	1944	1944	
Southsea	England	1			
Tamworth	England	1	1944	1944	
Tenby	Wales	1	1957	1957	
Torbay	England	1			
Torquay	England	1	1956	1956	
Walmer	England	1	1944	1944	
Westminster	England	1	1918	1918	
Weston-super-Mare	England	1	1932	1932	
Whitby	England	1	1956	1956	
Woolston	England	1	1918	1918	